Introduction. "The Sweetness of Heaven Overflows onto the Earth": Orthodox Christianity and Environmental Thought

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During the past few decades, the world has witnessed alarming environmental degradation—the threat of anthropogenic climate change, the loss of biodiversity, and the pollution of natural resources—along with the widening gap between rich and poor, as well as the increasing failure to implement environmental policies. We are reminded—in a painful way—of this crisis when we learn of the cruel extinction of flora and fauna and of irresponsible soil degradation and forest clearance, as well as when we endure unacceptable noise, air, and water pollution. Nonetheless, for Orthodox Christian philosophers and theologians, the concern for the environment is not a form of superficial or sentimental love. It is a way of honoring and dignifying the reality of our own creation by the hand and Word of God. It is, as well, a way of respecting "the mourning of the land" (Hosea 41:3) and heeding "the groaning of creation" (Rom. 8:22).

During this same period, one religious leader has notably discerned the signs of the times and called people's attention to this ecological and social situation. The worldwide leader of the Orthodox Churches, His All-Holiness Ecumenical Patriarch Bartholomew, has persistently proclaimed the primacy of spiritual values in determining environmental ethics and action. We are sincerely indebted to him for his spiritual leadership and pioneering initiatives as well as deeply grateful to him for his generosity in providing the foreword to this volume.

Western thought in the modern age has not been kind to the created world. From the exhortations of Galileo and Bacon that we subject it to violent interrogation to Descartes' vision of the natural environment as populated

with only seemingly animated robots, from the general Enlightenment concept of nature as a great machine to Hegel's view of the natural world as Spirit in a degraded and paralyzed condition, modern thought has given us a view of nature as something that is, in Max Weber's words, thoroughly "disenchanted"—drained of its power to elicit from us wonder and a sense of transcendence glimmering through and within it. And against the quiet, largely unheeded voice of Gerard Manley Hopkins reminding us that "there lives the dearest freshness deep down things," there is a far louder chorus decrying the very Christian faith that had originally allowed us to see and wonder and give thanks and praise—to approach nature no longer as the lair of treacherous, preternatural powers against which we must ever be wary but instead to see it as the gift of creation, God's initial, glorious revelation to humanity.

Indeed, beginning with Feuerbach and proceeding with Nietzsche, it was said that it was not Western modernity at all but Christianity itself that had silenced nature, subjugating the rich beauty of earth to the ethereal delights of heaven and degrading the earthly to mere matter given over to human control and exploitation. Perhaps the most influential proponent of this view has been Lynn White Jr., himself a Presbyterian layman, who argued that Christianity was singularly responsible for the present environmental crisis. According to White, as early as the thirteenth century the Latin West began to see nature as "a vast reservoir of energies to be tapped and used according to human intentions," and this promoted a violent, "arrogant," and dominating relation toward creation—leading us from seeing ourselves as "part of nature" to being "an exploiter of nature" entitled to exercise a now-characteristic "ruthlessness toward nature."[1]

Yet of those who actually read his essay "On the Historical Roots of Our Ecologic Crisis"—which has been endlessly cited, since its publication in the 1960s, as canonical in environmental literature—few stop to notice that at decisive points in his argument, White explicitly exempts the Christianity of the East from his critique, commending rather than censuring its view of creation:

> In the early Church, and *always in the Greek East*, nature was conceived primarily as *a symbolic system through which God speaks to men*. . . . This view of nature was *essentially artistic rather than scientific*. While Byzantium preserved and copied great numbers of ancient Greek scientific texts, science as we conceive it could scarcely flourish in such an ambiance. However in the Latin West by the early 13th century, natural theology was following a very different bent. It was ceasing to be the

> *decoding of the physical symbols of God's communication with man* and was becoming the effort to understand God's mind by discovering how his creation operates.[2]

White's understanding of Orthodox Christianity here is far from flawless. But his instincts are sound, for he sees that in the Christian East, as was the case in the earliest Christian thought of the patristic era, creation was understood not mechanically but aesthetically; not as an impersonally functioning mechanism but as the personal revelation of a loving Creator, a great gift that is meant to recall us to a relation to God within which alone our authentic happiness can be found; not as a free-standing substance with which to fabricate commodities to satisfy our desires but as an endless love poem being ever written by the Logos through Whom all things are made and meant for us to read and reread, to heed and treasure.

Understood more deeply, Orthodox Christianity holds a set of views that is not entirely absent in Western thought but that have not been grasped in their synergistic integrity outside Eastern lands and that have unhappily remained so thoroughly hidden from Western thought that it has (uncritically) adopted the Feuerbach-Nietzsche-White critique of Christianity as definitive, either abandoning Christianity altogether for the sake of a natural environment clearly in dire straits or else jettisoning much of the Christian tradition in favor of revisionist interpretations that are thought to be more salutary for our relation to the earth. Yet it is the claim of the present collection, taken as a whole, that it is solely on the basis of these very principles that we can embrace and articulate a spirituality that is adequate to the environmental tasks awaiting us.

What are these principles? Stated briefly, they proceed from the recognition—based upon a distinction long ignored or rejected in the Latin West—that while the divine essence (*ousia*) is eternally mysterious and unknowable, the uncreated energies or activity (*energeia*) of God can not only be known but encountered and experienced in this life and in this world, for they are at work everywhere around us. Connected with this is the realization that the Eternal Son of God, the Logos through whom the world is created, is mirrored and expressed in all things—in every leaf and blade of grass—as their inner meaning or depth, their *logoi*, thereby allowing us truly, in Blake's words, to see "Heaven in a wildflower." Hence, once the soul is purified (*katharsis*) through spiritual discipline (*askesis*), our Edenic ability to engage in a seeing of nature (*theoria physike*) can be at least partially restored to us—a discovery made, to some degree, independently in the West by nature poets and naturalists such as Thoreau and Muir. Seeing nature as

a divinely written icon, it is possible to praise the Creator and give thanks to Him for this beautiful creation, as the Psalms everywhere enjoin us. In doing so, we serve as a priesthood of creation, fulfilling the task for which we were ourselves created: not to exploit the created world after our own designs but rather to celebrate and consecrate and offer it back to the Creator—"Thine own of Thine own we offer unto Thee on behalf of all and for all," as the Divine Liturgy of the Orthodox Church proclaims. And in this set of theological insights, drawn not from speculative metaphysics but from the lived experience of the holy men and women whom Orthodox Christians recognize as saints—as "spiritual athletes" or "friends of God"—we believe there are principles upon which to build the theology and spirituality of which we, along with the earth that we have despoiled, stand in urgent need.

This collection of articles is the first substantial anthology, in any language, to address environmental issues from the point of view of Orthodox Christianity, and its contributors include many of the most highly respected Orthodox theologians and philosophers in recent decades. Corresponding to the *sobornost* or freedom-within-dialogue that is traditional to Orthodox intellectual life, readers will find here a perhaps surprising diversity and richness of writing styles, of theological and intellectual and methodological concerns, and of approaches to environmental issues. But overall, and especially for those accustomed to current trends in "ecotheology" and environmental philosophy, the reflections on environmental issues presented here will likely be found fresh and distinctive in several important ways:

1. The articles characteristically proceed from lived spirituality rather than religious doctrine, and when theological concepts are introduced, they are understood to be rooted in concrete religious experience.
2. Hence, they are often shaped more by noetic or mystical insight than by analysis and propositional argument, not infrequently employing language whose resonance is poetic.
3. Moreover, they characteristically draw upon the ontological roots of sacramental and liturgical sensibilities to point toward the often tacit, unexamined relations between creation and creator, visible and invisible, heaven and earth.
4. In addition, their approach is oriented cosmically rather than anthropocentrically, regarding the process of salvation or redemption as systemic and ecological in the broadest sense.
5. Finally, they are based upon a theology of Incarnation that looks toward the transfiguration of all creation as the ultimate goal of his-

tory, for which humanity would serve, humbly and contemplatively, as a cosmic priesthood celebrating and consecrating creation, and offering it back to its Creator—thereby addressing, more powerfully than he could have anticipated, Nietzsche's oft-cited challenge that thinking today "be true to the earth."

The compilation itself is organized around a quotation by the great mystic St. Isaac the Syrian:

> *What is knowledge? The experience of eternal life.*
>
> *And what is eternal life? The experience of all things in God.*
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> *For love comes from meeting God. Knowledge united to God fulfills every desire. And for the heart that receives it, it is altogether sweetness overflowing onto the earth. Indeed, there is nothing like the sweetness of God.*[3]

Our volume opens with a series of historical reflections in Part I, "'Knowledge United to God': Environment, Nature, and Creation in Patristic Thought," which examines central aspects of the understanding of nature, environment, and creation in the ancient Christianity of the first millennium. Part II, "'The Heart That Receives': Environment, Nature, and Creation in Twentieth-Century Orthodox Thought," shows that these ancient views have far more than antiquarian interest, engaging them with important issues and thinkers of the twentieth century. Part III, "'Love Comes from Meeting God': Historical, Theological, and Philosophical Dimensions," examines a variety of problems in environmental theory by employing the resources developed in the first two sections, exploring the concepts of "nature" and "creation" as competing rubrics for environmental understanding, the phenomenology of sacred space, and historical and ethical issues concerning ecology and environmentalism. Finally, Part IV, "'Sweetness Overflowing onto the Earth': Insights from Orthodox Spirituality," shows how the ideas presented earlier relate to the connection between living spirituality and our experience of the natural world around us.

This collection of essays boasts some of the most important voices within contemporary Orthodox thought both in North America and in Europe—what we feel is an embarrassment of riches featuring some of its most respected hierarchs and its most celebrated scholars, its monks and professors, its clergy and scientists and poets. It will be a rare reader who will not discover treasures here. At the same time, it brings together new and original contributions with articles that have become classics in Orthodox circles yet that are currently unobtainable because they were first printed in small

editions. Nor is it univocal in its conclusions, offering a rich display of the diversity of Orthodox thinking. We believe that *Toward an Ecology of Transfiguration:*

has the potential to become a groundbreaking volume, not just as pointing toward new horizons in environmental thought but as a contribution to the millennial attempt to reconcile East and West, Byzantine and Latin, if not initially as complementary components of a single *ekkelsia*, then at least as dedicated, serious participants in a common and globally critical project of offering to the world hope for the possibility of a viable and salutary future—one for which the reality named by terms such as nature and environment and creation is more than a memory or an aspiration but a living benediction and icon of divine grace. It is a book that we hope will engage a very wide audience in academic as well as more popular circles—not only Orthodox audiences but just as much those who are simply looking for a fresh, provocative approach to environmental thought that brings to bear the resources of ancient spirituality upon modern perplexities.

We are especially honored to include in this anthology the writing of three prophetic figures in the development of an Orthodox sensitivity to the environment. As in many other aspects of his thinking, Nikos Nissiotis (1924–1986) spoke and wrote of creation theology among international and ecumenical circles well before anyone considered its significance. Philip Sherrard (1922–1995) was the first Orthodox theologian to articulate a systematic approach to the ecological crisis, doubtless drawing upon his experience of monasticism and his exposure to the classic texts of the *Philokalia*. And Savas Agouridis (1921–2009), a biblical scholar in Greece, was among the first and few Orthodox theologians in the past century to call into question the conservative approach to the Church Fathers while emphasizing the social depth of the gospel message. Along with articles by these three authors, we are also honored to include an essay by the late Donald Sheehan (1940–2010) of Dartmouth University and the Robert Frost Place.

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